

FOR TRADES AND SMALL SERVICE BUSINESSES

The DIY Leak Audit

Ten ways money leaks out of a business like yours. Read it in 20 minutes, tick the ones that sting, fix the worst of them this week. No spreadsheets, no homework. Just a pen.

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The same ten leaks I check when a business pays me to find them.

Read this first

A leak is money you already did the work to earn, going to someone else or going nowhere. The call that rang the next name on the list. The quote that died in your head on a Friday night. The invoice you never sent. Prices that haven't moved since materials did. None of it needs new customers. It is your money, already in motion, falling out of the bucket.

THIS IS NOT HOMEWORK

Ten leaks, one page each. Read each page and if it stings, tick the box at the bottom. That's the whole job. Your ticks tell you what to fix, the 4 day plan at the back tells you how to start. If you want exact euro figures there's a page at the back for that too, but you don't need them to act. You already know where it hurts.

HOWEVER YOUR WORK COMES IN

Callouts all week, big projects that run for months, steady contracts, or no two weeks the same. Doesn't matter. The leaks are the same, only the size of the number changes. Where money examples appear, there's a version for your kind of week.

THE THREE LEVERS

Every fix in here pulls at least one of three levers: it makes you money, it saves you time, or it lifts the quality of the work. If a fix someone is selling you pulls none of them, you don't need it.

Two honesty rules. This book deals in honest ranges, not fake precision, every business is different and anyone who gives you an exact figure without seeing your books is selling you something. And you will fix the biggest leak first, not the easiest one. The easy one feels good. The big one pays.

LEAK 1

The missed call

SOUND FAMILIAR?

"It goes to voicemail." "I ring back when I'm off the ladder." "I'd miss a few a week." "What usually happens? Honestly, nothing."

WHAT IT'S COSTING YOU

Roughly 3 in 10 missed callers would have booked. The rest were never going to, that's the honest number. But the 3 don't wait, they ring the next name on the list and never think about you again. If you're a callout trade, every one of those is a whole job, €80 to €300 gone in the time it took to not answer. If you do bigger work, one missed call can be the €15,000 job you never even knew existed. That's the cruelty of this leak, you never see what it took.

THE HARD QUESTION

How many calls went to voicemail this week, and where do you think those people rang next?

FIRST MOVE

Missed call text back. The second a call goes unanswered, a text fires by itself: "Sorry I missed you, on a job, tell me what you need and I'll come straight back." It catches the lead before they dial the next lad. Until that's set up, the free version is a habit: text back within five minutes, every time, no exceptions.

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Tick it if it stung.

Slow to quote

SOUND FAMILIAR?

"Quotes pile up." "It rattles around in my head for days before it's sent." "I do them when I get a spare evening." "Some never go out at all."

WHAT IT'S COSTING YOU

First price in usually wins the job, everyone in the trade knows it and everyone forgets it on a Friday. A lost quote is a whole job, a couple of hundred for a small one, five figures if you do project work. And the quotes that never went out at all are worse, you did the site visit, you did the thinking, you paid the diesel, then handed the job to whoever answered faster. That's work you did for the other fella.

THE HARD QUESTION

Of the last ten prices you were asked for, how many went out the same day? And where do you reckon the slow ones went?

FIRST MOVE

Templates. Take your last good quote, strip out the customer's details, that's now your template. Every new quote is fill in the blanks from the phone, out the same evening. Five minutes, not forty. The bigger version turns a voice note from the van into a tidy quote before you've left the driveway.

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Tick it if it stung.

LEAK 3

Money you're owed, sitting out there

SOUND FAMILIAR?

"The invoice goes out when I get around to it." "Often a month or more to get paid." "I'm forever chasing people." "I hate asking for money."

WHAT IT'S COSTING YOU

This is the one leak you can count to the euro tonight, because it's not a maybe, it's your money in other people's accounts. Finished jobs never invoiced. Invoices sent and never chased. The awkwardness of asking, priced in cash. Meanwhile you're the one sweating the van payment on money you already earned.

THE HARD QUESTION

If you added up everything you're owed right now, tonight, what's the number? Go on. You already half know it.

FIRST MOVE

Invoice from the phone before you leave the job, while you're both standing there. Then two reminder texts, day 7 and day 14, the same two lines every time, so chasing stops being personal and starts being the system. "Just a nudge on that invoice, tap the link and it's done." A pay by card link finishes it, they pay on the spot.

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Tick it if it stung.

LEAK 4

Quotes going cold, nobody chased

SOUND FAMILIAR?

"Once a quote's out I forget about it." "A fair few never get chased back." "How many are sitting out there? No idea, honestly, and that's probably the answer."

WHAT IT'S COSTING YOU

A quote with no answer isn't a no. Half the time the customer got busy, lost the text, or is waiting to feel sure. One follow up text turns some of them into jobs, for free, and almost nobody sends it because it feels like begging. It isn't. It's the most profitable text in the trade. And the old customers in your phone are the same leak wearing a different coat, gold sitting idle, a full list of people who already trust you.

THE HARD QUESTION

How many quotes are sitting out there right now with no answer, and when did you last chase one?

FIRST MOVE

Tonight, chase your three newest unanswered quotes, word for word: "Hi [name], following up on the quote from [day], will I pencil you in for next week?" Then once a season, one text to the old customer list: "Jack here, any jobs need doing before the winter? I've a slot free next week." Change the name, obviously.

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Tick it if it stung.

LEAK 5

Your time, buried in the office

SOUND FAMILIAR?

"The books on a Sunday night." "Paperwork after the tea, every night." "Most of an evening, gone." "I didn't start a business to do this."

WHAT IT'S COSTING YOU

Count it honestly and it frightens people: for a lot of owners the office side is the best part of a day a week, sometimes more. That's a full working day nobody pays for. At an office rate of €25 an hour it's thousands a year. If those evenings are also the reason quotes go out late, it's feeding Leak 2 as well. And the dearest part isn't euro at all, it's that the reason you started the business is the thing getting squeezed out of it.

THE HARD QUESTION

What were you doing at the kitchen table after ten last night, and who paid for that hour?

FIRST MOVE

Name the single biggest drain. Not "admin", one job, the books or the quotes or the receipts. Then cut its steps in half before you buy anything: done once instead of weekly, on the phone instead of at the table, a photo instead of typing. Automate last, not first.

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Tick it if it stung.

LEAK 6

Paying for tools you never use

SOUND FAMILIAR?

*"I signed up for something last year, never used it." "I'm paying for I don't even know what."
"There's a direct debit I keep meaning to look at."*

WHAT IT'S COSTING YOU

Straight money out the door every month for nothing. The app you used twice. The directory listing that never sent a job. The tracker on the van you sold. It's usually the smallest leak in this book and it still goes first, because it's pure arithmetic, there's nothing to learn, nothing to break, and nothing to argue with. The bank statement never forgets a direct debit, even when you do.

THE HARD QUESTION

Open the bank app. How many direct debits can you not explain in one sentence?

FIRST MOVE

Kill them today. All of them. Ten minutes in the bank app and the money stops leaving. This is Day 1 of the plan at the back, your first win, done before the dinner.

☐

Tick it if it stung.

LEAK 7

Drowning in messages, the same ones

SOUND FAMILIAR?

"WhatsApp, email, texts, it never ends." "I'm answering the same five questions every single day." "The phone never stops and none of it is work."

WHAT IT'S COSTING YOU

Two costs, and they stack. The hours: count one honest day of thumb time and multiply, most owners guess two hours a week and it's closer to six or eight. And the leads: a slow reply is a cold lead, people message three tradesmen and go with whoever answers like a business. Meanwhile most of what you're typing is the same five answers, price range, availability, area covered, over and over, forever.

THE HARD QUESTION

What five questions do you answer every single day that a page could answer once?

FIRST MOVE

Two moves, one evening. Saved replies on the phone for the five messages you type most, including "on a job, back to you at six". Then answer the five questions once, in public, where people look before they message: your Google profile, your socials, a pinned WhatsApp reply. Every question answered in public is a message that never arrives.

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Tick it if it stung.

LEAK 8

The diary in your head

SOUND FAMILIAR?

"It's all up here." "A notebook in the van." "I've double booked before, aye." "I drove the county in the wrong order on Tuesday."

WHAT IT'S COSTING YOU

A missed slot is a lost job today, and a customer who doesn't ring next time, the second cost is the one that compounds. Add the diesel and the hours from doing jobs in whatever order they came to mind, and the mental load of being the only backup copy of your own week. A head is a terrible filing cabinet and yours is doing it on top of a full day's work.

THE HARD QUESTION

When did you last double book, forget a job, or drive the wrong way round the county, and what did that day actually cost?

FIRST MOVE

One calendar, on the phone, and every job goes in the minute it's agreed, standing in the driveway if needs be. No notebook backup, one place. The bigger version is a booking link, customers pick a slot themselves and the phone tag dies.

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Tick it if it stung.

LEAK 9

Invisible on Google

SOUND FAMILIAR?

"Word of mouth only." "I don't ask for reviews, it feels like begging." "I know I should sort Google, I never did."

WHAT IT'S COSTING YOU

When someone new needs your trade, they google it and ring one of the top few names. Reviews are a known part of who ranks, so every happy customer who left no review is free advertising you did the work for and never collected. Word of mouth is real but it clocks off at night. Google doesn't. This is the one leak that compounds in your favour once you turn it around, it builds while you sleep.

THE HARD QUESTION

Google your trade and your town right now. Who comes up first, and how many reviews does he have on you?

FIRST MOVE

Text your last five happy customers the direct review link tonight, two taps for them. Then it's a habit: link goes out the day after every job, every job, forever. And claim your Google Business Profile properly, photos, hours, areas, it's free and half your competition never bothered.



Tick it if it stung.

Charging too little

SOUND FAMILIAR?

"Same prices for years." "I'd be afraid to lose the regulars." "There's lads dearer than me doing worse work."

WHAT IT'S COSTING YOU

Materials went up. Diesel went up. Insurance went up. If your prices stood still through all of that, you gave yourself a pay cut every year and called it loyalty. And here's the part nobody says out loud: a 10 percent rise on every job is nearly pure profit, the costs don't move, only your side does. On €80,000 of work that's €8,000 for the same year's graft. The lads dearer than you aren't better than you. They just asked.

THE HARD QUESTION

When did you last put your prices up? Everything you buy went up since. Who's been paying the difference?

FIRST MOVE

Your next quote goes out 10 percent higher. Not the regulars if you're not ready, just the next new job. Watch what happens, which is usually nothing, they say grand and you've been underpaid for years. Then do it again next year, on schedule, like the builders' providers do to you.

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Tick it if it stung.

The tick sheet

Bring your ticks forward. This is the page to photograph.

STUNG LEAK

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1. The missed call

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2. Slow to quote

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3. Money you're owed, sitting out there

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4. Quotes going cold, nobody chased

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5. Your time, buried in the office

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6. Paying for tools you never use

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7. Drowning in messages, the same ones

☐

8. The diary in your head

☐

9. Invisible on Google

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10. Charging too little

WHAT YOUR TICKS MEAN

0 to 2. Tight ship. Fix the one that stung worst and keep this in the van for the day things slip.

3 to 5. Normal, and expensive. Between them these are quietly costing you thousands a year. Pick the biggest, not the easiest.

6 or more. The business is running on your back and on luck. The good news: every one of these has a first move you can start this week, and most of them are free.

Now circle the biggest one. Not the easiest. The biggest. That's the one that pays for everything else.

Your 4 day plan

One move a day beats ten moves planned. Every move is free and on its leak page in full.

DAY 1

Kill the dead subscriptions (Leak 6) and **text the review link to your last five happy customers** (Leak 9). Money stops leaving, ranking starts building, under an hour, done before the dinner.

DAY 2

Chase every quote sitting unanswered (Leak 4). The word for word text is on the page. Watch what comes back by the weekend.

DAY 3

Build your quote template (Leak 2) and **your five saved replies** (Leak 7). One evening, both done, and tomorrow's quotes go out same day.

DAY 4

One calendar, every job in it (Leak 8), and **your next quote goes out 10 percent up** (Leak 10). And decide your answer to the missed call (Leak 1), even if for now it's texting back inside five minutes yourself.

If you only ever do Day 1 and Day 2, you're already ahead of most businesses your size, and this book has paid for itself several times over. The rest is compounding.

TRIED TO SORT THIS BEFORE?

Most owners have. Bought a tool off an ad, used it twice, back to the notebook inside a month. The tool was never the problem. Nobody found the biggest leak first and set things up around how you actually work. That's the difference between buying software and fixing a leak, and it's why this book made you find the leaks before it let you near a fix.

Want your exact number?

You don't need it to act, the ticks are enough. But if you want euro on it, here's the honest two minute version of each. Count real things, never guess.

Missed calls.

Calls missed in a week, times 3 in 10 that would have booked, times what a typical job is worth to you, times 48 working weeks.

Slow quotes and cold quotes.

Jobs in the last year you know went elsewhere because the price was late or never chased, times what those jobs were worth. Painful and honest.

Money owed.

No formula. Add up unpaid invoices and uninvoiced finished jobs, tonight. That's the number.

Office evenings.

Hours a week on the office side, times €25, times 48. If it's costing you jobs too, price the hours at your trade rate instead and brace yourself.

Dead subscriptions.

The monthly total off the bank statement, times 12.

Underpricing.

Last year's turnover, times 10 percent. That's roughly what one overdue price rise is worth, and it's nearly all profit.

The honesty cap. Estimates stack up flattering. If your total comes out above 15 percent of what the business turns over in a year, use the smaller number. And the fastest way to a proper figure: my free calculator asks how your work comes in, callouts, projects or contracts, and does the maths off your own answers:

jackoreg1.github.io/leak-finder

You found them yourself

With a book and a pen, in 20 minutes. That already puts you ahead of nearly every business your size, most owners feel the leaks for years and never once look at them straight. Everything in the 4 day plan is free and yours. Do it this week while it stings.

IF YOU'D RATHER HAND IT OVER

That's what I do. The full version of this isn't a book, it's me: half an hour on a call finding the leaks this book can't see from the outside, then a written report on your business specifically, every leak ranked and costed off your own numbers, each fix marked do it yourself or hand it to me. The quick stuff you run yourself off a plan like the one in this book, built for you. The bigger builds, if you want them, I do, and nothing goes live until it's tested end to end.

You ticked what you ticked. Doing nothing about it now has a price, and you're the one who just worked it out.

WhatsApp me: wa.me/353894794158

Say "leak audit" and tell me which leak you circled. No hard sell, if the 4 day plan is all you need, I'll tell you that straight.

Jack O'Regan, Cork.

I find where a business is leaking money, then fix it so it stays fixed.

Every figure this book helps you produce is an estimate built from your own inputs. It's a torch for deciding what to fix first, not a promise of earnings.